> I began as a member of “Hashomer Hatzair” [“the young guardian,” a Zionist Marxist political movement], in that atmosphere filled with emotions, under a crossfire from both sides: a messianic longing stemming from Eastern Europe and a Zionist fire from Eretz Israel. The messianic longing was born in me, the obsession, the *dibbuk* of the idea of salvation entered into me. [Talmon, “Socialism and Liberalism,” *From the foundations* [Hebrew], 1962]

What Talmon meant by messianic fire from Eastern Europe is not entirely clear; he was probably alluding to Marxism, mixed with those vague longings for salvation that suffused the small and oppressed Jewish communities of Poland. This was not representative of the urban Jews of Warsaw or Krakow, and even less so of Jews from Germany or Western Europe of the pre-Nazi years. But because East European Jews of Talmon’s generation were dominant among immigrants to Eretz Israel, the question of a messianic urge among those Zionists demands some more attention.

It may be remembered that I wondered whether the kind of messianic urge that erupted in Israel with victory in the Six-Day War had suffused Zionism from its very beginning. I still do not believe that religious talk of hearing the “steps of the Messiah” had anything to do with the kind of messianic longing mentioned by Talmon. I knew Talmon well and, as far as I could tell, he did not show the least sign of religiosity. There was an urge for salvation among the masses of East European Jews, but for a salvation from oppression, from life in the Golah, for Eretz Israel as the longed-for site of such salvation. Among the majority, there was no need for the whole land of Israel; a state was their maximum demand.

Incidentally, Talmon was one of the most courageous polemicists against the triumphalism in Israeli society following the Six-Day War and the early moves to settle the West Bank. In my view, his articles of those days in *Haaretz* were unmatched in their sharp analysis of the dire consequences of Israel’s policies.

I didn’t hold it against Talmon that, in 1961, when I resigned from my job at the Ministry of Defense and wished to resume my doctoral studies, he